

Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy

Protecting the welfare of every young person in our care

15-17 Irlam Road, Bootle, Liverpool, L20 4AE · Alternative Provision for Ages 5–25

ADOPTED POLICY

This policy has been formally adopted by L-Fit Pathways' co-directors and is in effect from the date shown below. Any section still shown in [square brackets and amber text] is organisation-specific detail that remains to be confirmed and inserted - it does not affect the rest of the policy's validity but should be completed as soon as possible.

Version: 1.0 (Adopted)

Date Adopted: 16 September 2026

Next Review Due: 16 September 2027 (or sooner following any legislative change or safeguarding incident)

1. Statement of Intent

L-Fit Pathways is committed to safeguarding and promoting the welfare of all children and young people accessing our provision, and expects all staff, volunteers and visitors to share this commitment. The welfare of the child is paramount. Every young person, regardless of age, disability, gender, racial heritage, religious belief, sexual orientation or identity, has the right to be protected from all forms of abuse, neglect and exploitation.

This policy applies to Adam Byrne and Craig Lloyd (Co-Directors and Designated Safeguarding Leads), all staff, sessional workers, volunteers and any visiting professionals working with young people through L-Fit Pathways.

2. Legal & Statutory Framework

This policy has been written with regard to:

- Keeping Children Safe in Education (KCSIE) 2026 — DfE statutory guidance, effective 1 September 2026
- Working Together to Safeguard Children (2026)
- Children Act 1989 and Children Act 2004
- Education Act 1996, Section 19 (duty to arrange suitable education — the basis of EOTAS placements)
- Arranging Alternative Provision — DfE Guidance for Local Authorities and Schools
- SEND Code of Practice 2015 (0–25 years)
- Equality Act 2010
- UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018
- The Prevent Duty (Counter-Terrorism and Security Act 2015)
- Sefton Safeguarding Children Partnership and Liverpool Safeguarding Children Partnership procedures

3. Roles & Responsibilities

Designated Safeguarding Leads (DSLs)

Adam Byrne and Craig Lloyd are joint Designated Safeguarding Leads for L-Fit Pathways. Both are Level 5 Safeguarding/DSL trained and hold current Enhanced DBS checks. A trained DSL is contactable at all times during provision hours.

- Adam Byrne — adam.byrne@lfitpathways.com
- Craig Lloyd — craig.lloyd@lfitpathways.com

The DSLs are responsible for: receiving and acting on all safeguarding concerns; making referrals to children's social care, the police or the LADO as appropriate; liaising with referring schools, colleges and local authorities; maintaining accurate, secure safeguarding records; and ensuring all staff receive appropriate safeguarding training.

All Staff and Volunteers

Every adult working with young people at L-Fit Pathways has an equal responsibility to act on any concern about a child's welfare, and must report concerns to a DSL on the same day they arise — never investigate a concern themselves.

4. Recognising Abuse & Neglect

Staff are trained to recognise the four categories of abuse defined in Working Together to Safeguard Children: physical abuse, emotional abuse, sexual abuse and neglect. Staff are also alert to contextual safeguarding risks relevant to the young people we work with, including:

- Child sexual exploitation (CSE) and child criminal exploitation (CCE), including county lines
- Radicalisation and extremism (Prevent)
- Peer-on-peer abuse, including harmful sexual behaviour
- Online risk, including grooming and harmful content
- Emotionally-based school avoidance (EBSA) as a potential indicator of wider difficulty
- Domestic abuse in the home
- Faith-based abuse and so-called honour-based abuse

5. Responding to a Disclosure or Concern

Any member of staff who receives a disclosure or has a concern must:

- Listen carefully without promising confidentiality
- Not ask leading questions
- Record what was said as close to verbatim as possible, using the child's own words, signed and dated
- Report to a DSL on the same day, without delay

The DSL will determine whether a referral to children's social care, the police, and/or the Local Authority Designated Officer (LADO) is required, in line with local threshold guidance.

Key Local Contacts

- Sefton Children's Help and Advice Team (CHAT) - front door for safeguarding concerns/referrals: 0151 934 4013

- Sefton Emergency Duty Team (outside office hours, weekends, bank holidays): 0151 934 3555
- Sefton LADO (Local Authority Designated Officer): 0151 934 3783
- Liverpool Children's Social Care (concerns/referrals): 0151 459 2606
- Liverpool LADO: via Careline Children Services, carelinechildrenservices@liverpool.gov.uk, or LADO@liverpool.gov.uk
- Emergency Police contact: 999 (immediate risk) / 101 (non-emergency)

6. Allegations Against Staff or Volunteers

Any allegation against a member of staff or volunteer will be reported immediately to the LADO and handled in line with KCSIE 2026 Part 4, independently of the individual concerned. Where the allegation concerns a DSL, it will be referred to the other Co-Director/DSL and the LADO directly.

7. Safer Recruitment

All staff and volunteers are recruited in line with our Safer Recruitment & DBS Policy, including Enhanced DBS checks, identity verification, reference checks and (from September 2026, per KCSIE 2026) DBS checks for all volunteers with no supervision exemption.

8. Whistleblowing

Any member of staff who has concerns about the practice of a colleague, including either DSL, has a duty to raise this. Concerns can be raised directly with a DSL, or where this is not appropriate, escalated to the LADO or the NSPCC Whistleblowing Advice Line.

9. Online Safety, Devices & Photography

Staff mobile phones are not used to photograph young people. Any photography or video for promotional, training or session-record purposes requires specific written parental/carers consent, recorded against the child's referral file. Young people's use of devices during sessions is supervised in line with our approach to online safety.

10. Physical Intervention

L-Fit Pathways' Boxing Fitness provision is strictly non-contact. Physical intervention or restraint is only ever used as an absolute last resort to prevent immediate harm, in line with DfE guidance on the use of reasonable force, and is always recorded, reported to a DSL and communicated to parents/carers on the same day.

11. Missing Child Procedure

Attendance is recorded at the start and end of every session. Should a young person go missing during provision, staff will immediately search the immediate area, notify a DSL, contact the parent/carers and referring professional, and contact the police if the young person is not located within a reasonable timeframe or immediate risk is suspected.

12. Confidentiality & Information Sharing

Safeguarding information is shared only on a need-to-know basis, in line with our Data Protection Policy. Information will always be shared without consent where a child is at risk of harm, in accordance with Working Together to Safeguard Children.

13. Training

Both DSLs hold Level 5 Safeguarding/DSL qualifications and refresh training in line with statutory timescales. All staff and volunteers receive safeguarding induction training before working unsupervised with young people, and refresher training at least annually.

14. Monitoring & Review

This policy is reviewed annually by the Co-Directors/DSLs, or immediately following any safeguarding incident, changes to statutory guidance, or Ofsted/DfE regulatory update.

Policy adopted on: 16 September 2026 — Next review due: 16 September 2027